The letter arrived on a Tuesday and my grandmother read it twice before she spoke, folding it along the old creases while the kettle hissed behind her on the stove.

> *We shall come home when the river allows,*
> *and not a day before; tell the children*
> *that the boat is sound and the men are well.*

She put the letter in the tin with the others and said nothing more about it that day, though at supper she set two extra places, just in case the river was kind.